# English Goes Global

AP Human Geography · Unit 3 · One stimulus (like Question 2) · 7 points · Teacher key · GeoArcade FRQ Tutor

The English language is spoken in many countries, but at very different rates. India and China each have more than 1.3 billion people. India has more English speakers than China, but the number of English speakers is growing in both countries.

**Number of English Speakers in Selected Countries, 2018 (population above age five)**

| Country | Number of English speakers | Percent of population who speak English |
|---|---|---|
| **China** | 10 million | less than 1% |
| **India** | 125 million | 12% |
| **Netherlands** | 15 million | 90% |
| **Nigeria** | 79 million | 53% |
| **Philippines** | 92 million | 95% |
| **Sweden** | 8 million | 86% |
| **United Kingdom** | 60 million | 98% |
| **United States** | 296 million | 96% |

*Source: Ethnologue. Remember the class directions: label each part, and write Describe and Explain parts as T1- (your reason in general words), E2- (the specific proof), A3- (why it matters).*

**A. Describe ONE historical reason for India's current number of English speakers.** DESCRIBE

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names a historical reason: British colonial rule of India
- Describes how English spread or stayed: used in government, schools, or business, and kept after independence

MODEL ANSWER

**T1-** India has many English speakers today because it was a British colony.
**E2-** Under the British Raj (1858–1947), English was the language of government, courts, and universities, so educated Indians had to learn it.
**A3-** After independence, India kept English as an official language, partly as a neutral link between its many regional languages, so it is still widely spoken.

**Common mistake:** “India speaks English because it is a big country.” Size doesn't explain language. China is just as big and has under 1% English speakers. You need the history.

**Why the model works:** It names the history (British colonial rule), gives specific proof (government, courts, universities), and explains why English lasted after 1947.

**B. Explain ONE contemporary reason why people in China and India are learning English.** EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names a present-day reason: globalization, business, jobs, studying abroad, the internet, or tourism
- Explains how English helps (more opportunities, higher pay, communicating with the world)

MODEL ANSWER

**T1-** People in China and India are learning English because it is the global lingua franca of business.
**E2-** Multinational companies, tech firms, and call centers hire workers who can speak English with customers and partners around the world.
**A3-** Because English skills open these better-paying jobs, learning English can raise a person's income and help the country compete in the global economy.

**Common mistake:** "English is the best language." That's an opinion, not a reason, and it doesn't explain what English does for people in China or India.

**Why the model works:** It names a present-day reason (global business), gives an example (jobs with multinational companies), and explains the payoff (higher income).

**C. Describe ONE barrier to the diffusion of English throughout China.** DESCRIBE

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names a barrier: government policy, Mandarin emphasis, internet limits, language difference, few teachers, rural access, no British colonial history, or cultural pride
- Describes how it slows English from spreading in China

MODEL ANSWER

**T1-** One barrier to English spreading in China is government control over information.
**E2-** China's "Great Firewall" blocks many English-language websites, and the government promotes Mandarin as the national language.
**A3-** Because people in China have fewer chances to see and use English online or in daily life, English spreads slowly, which helps explain why fewer than 1% of people there speak it.

**Common mistake:** "English is hard." Too vague. Hard for whom, and why? Name a specific barrier in China and describe how it slows English.

**Why the model works:** It names a specific barrier (government control), gives proof (the Great Firewall, Mandarin policy), and describes the effect (fewer chances to use English).

**D. Using the table, explain ONE reason for the difference in the percentage of English speakers in the Netherlands compared with the percentage in China.** EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Uses the table: the Netherlands is 90% vs. China under 1%
- Explains a reason: similar language, trade/globalization, closeness to the UK, media, schools, or China's huge Mandarin-speaking market

MODEL ANSWER

**T1-** The Netherlands has a much higher share of English speakers (90%) than China (less than 1%) partly because Dutch and English are closely related languages.
**E2-** Both are Germanic languages in the Indo-European family, so they share many words and grammar patterns, while Mandarin uses tones and characters.
**A3-** Because English is much easier for Dutch speakers to learn, and they hear it constantly through trade and English-language TV, a far larger percentage of Dutch people become fluent.

**Common mistake:** "The Netherlands has more English speakers than China." That just restates the table. It gives no reason at all. The question asks you to explain WHY the percentages are so different.

**Why the model works:** It quotes the table, names a reason (language similarity), and explains how it leads to more English speakers.

**E. Explain ONE economic reason why a corporation based in an English-speaking country would locate a call center in a country where English is not the dominant language.** EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names an economic reason: lower wages/labor costs, a large English-speaking workforce, time zones, or tax incentives
- Explains how it benefits the corporation (saves money, raises profits, 24-hour service)

MODEL ANSWER

**T1-** A corporation might put a call center in a country like India because labor costs are much lower there.
**E2-** India has about 125 million English speakers, so companies can hire many workers who speak English but earn far lower wages than workers in the United States.
**A3-** Paying lower wages for the same service cuts the company's costs, which raises its profits.

**Common mistake:** "Because people in other countries need jobs." That's about the workers, not the corporation. The question asks for an economic reason that benefits the company.

**Why the model works:** It names the economic reason (lower labor costs), uses the table (125 million English speakers in India), and explains the payoff (higher profits).

**F. Explain ONE limitation of using the data in the table to understand a country's level of economic development.** EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- States a limitation: language data doesn't measure income, GDP per capita, HDI, health, or education (or it's one year / national averages)
- Explains why that's misleading, ideally with an example (the Philippines is 95% but less developed than China)

MODEL ANSWER

**T1-** One limitation is that the table measures how many people speak English, not how wealthy or developed a country is.
**E2-** For example, the Philippines is 95% English-speaking, but it has a much lower GDP per capita than China, where less than 1% speak English.
**A3-** Because English ability doesn't track development, using this table alone could lead someone to the wrong conclusion about which countries are more developed.

**Common mistake:** "The table doesn't show every country." That's about how many countries are listed, not about measuring development. Explain what kind of data is missing.

**Why the model works:** It names what's missing (economic data), gives a clear example (the Philippines vs. China), and explains how it could mislead.

**G. Explain ONE negative local impact of a global lingua franca on places where a different language is spoken.** EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names a negative impact: language loss or extinction, loss of local culture, cultural homogenization, or inequality for non-English speakers
- Explains how the lingua franca causes it locally

MODEL ANSWER

**T1-** One negative local impact of English as a global lingua franca is the loss of local languages.
**E2-** When young people use English for school, jobs, and the internet, they may stop speaking their family's language, so fewer children learn it.
**A3-** As a local language fades, the stories, traditions, and knowledge tied to it can be lost, weakening the place's cultural identity.

**Common mistake:** "English is bad for other countries." Too vague and too broad. Name a specific local impact and explain how the lingua franca causes it.

**Why the model works:** It names a specific impact (language loss), explains how it happens (young people switch to English), and why it matters (traditions and identity).